



New playmates With licensed child-care homes or day-care centers your baby interacts with others and learn, at a young age, how to play with others.



Family care

The setup: grandparents, uncles, and aunts take on the responsibility of caregiver. This can also take on the form of shared care between the parents.



What to think about: depending on whether you pay your relatives, this can be one of the more cost-effective options and is particularly appropriate if the family members live nearby. Your child will be taken care of by those who love her and will be in a familiar environment. Care can also be divided between parents. In all instances of shared family care, it is vital to establish a consistent routine and rules of behavior.



Au Pair

The setup: these are generally young people who have come to the US to improve their language skills and who live with you. They have their own room and receive board and lodging, as well as some money.



What to think about: they are classified as a member of the family and as such, live in your house, have meals with you, and accompany you on outings. In return they undertake household and child-care duties, but generally for not more than 45 hours per week. Many do not have any training or previous experience of child care and you may not have the chance to meet them before they start.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

When visiting a day-care center or meeting a caregiver, it is a good idea to write down a few questions beforehand. Here are some issues you might want to ask about:

» **What will my child's daily routine be?** Usually a licensed child-care home will be happy to use your baby's current routine or might be able to suggest an alternative one. At a center, since there are so many babies, they may encourage her to fit in with the others.

» **What will my baby be fed and where will she sleep?** A day-care center will likely ask you to supply them with enough bottles filled with breast milk or baby formula to last all day. All care providers should have a quiet room for babies to nap in.

» **How will you keep me informed of my child's progress?** Both licensed child-care homes and other day-care centers should keep a developmental record of your child's progress. You should be able to access this at any time and it may be sent home to you so that you can review and add to it yourself.

» **How do you deal with challenging behavior?** All children need boundaries to keep them safe, but make sure you are happy with how the potential caregiver disciplines children and ask to see their policy document.

» **What is the illness policy?** Most child-care settings are happy to accept children with minor coughs and colds, but your child will need to go home and be kept home if she has a fever, sickness, or anything more serious. Ask to see the policy document regarding illness.

» **What are your qualifications?** It can be reassuring to know that the person taking care of your baby is fully qualified so check that day-care center staff or nannies have the relevant recognized child-care qualifications and up-to-date certificates for first aid. Always follow up on references.